Case Study

The feature nobody uses

Google Pay has a split bill feature. Nobody at the table used it. · Aryan Srivastava · April 2025

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Last October I went to a dhaba in Lucknow with seven friends. One bill, eight people, everyone on Google Pay. Someone at the table said hey, GPay has a split thing, let's use that.

What happened next is the whole case study.

Two people said 'it does?' Three said they'd tried it once and found it confusing. One person opened the app and couldn't find it. One person found it but it asked him to create a group first and he didn't want to do that right now. We ended up doing what we always do one person paid, put the total in the group chat, and we individually transferred our shares one by one over the next twenty minutes.

That's eight people who actively use GPay, in a moment where splitting was the obvious thing to do, with a built-in feature designed for exactly this situation and not a single one of us used it.

That bothered me. Not in a 'how could GPay mess this up' way. More like something interesting is happening here and I want to understand what it actually is.

> *The feature exists. The intent was there. The phones were in everyone's hands. Something between those things and the actual split going through is where this case study lives.*

What I did to understand it

I used the feature myself about a dozen times over the following two weeks different amounts, different groups, different scenarios. I read through every Play Store review that mentioned 'split' or 'group' in the context of GPay. I asked friends who had tried it what stopped them. I looked at how Splitwise, CRED, and PhonePe handle the same use case. And I wrote down everything that felt wrong, not just what I could articulate immediately.

What I found surprised me a bit. The problem isn't what most people would assume it is.

What's actually broken

The instinct when a feature has low usage is to say it's hard to find. Move the button, add an onboarding tooltip, A/B test the placement. That framing felt wrong here.

My friend who opened the app and couldn't find the split feature he found it eventually. He opened it. And then he stopped because it asked him to create a group. The issue wasn't discovery. It was that the first thing the feature asked him to do was something he hadn't planned to do that evening.

That's a different problem entirely.

The group has to exist before the expense does

GPay's split lives inside the Groups section. To split a bill, you need a pre-made group in the app. Not a WhatsApp group a GPay group. A separate thing you'd have had to set up before you went to dinner.

Think about how groups actually form in real life. You don't maintain a standing 'Thursday dinner friends' group in your payment app. You go out, you look around at who's there, and then you figure out the money at the end. The group forms around the event. GPay's design requires the group to exist before the event, which is backwards from how people actually behave.

Splitwise figured this out years ago. You can add people to a split on the spot, using just a phone number, even if they're not on the app. The split happens first. The group is a byproduct. GPay does it the other way around.

> *Nobody thinks 'I should set up my Friday dinner group on GPay' on a Tuesday. They think about splitting money when they're about to split money. That's when the feature needs to work, not as something you set up in advance.*

Equal splits are almost never what actually happened

Once you get past the group setup, the feature divides the bill equally. No options.

Except here's the thing we went to a dhaba. One person ordered extra starters. Two people didn't drink anything. Someone had already bought petrol on the way and said just take it off my share. Equal splits sound fair in the abstract and are almost never accurate in practice.

The result: you use the split feature, get back an amount that doesn't match what you owe, and then spend mental energy reconciling the difference anyway. At that point you've added steps rather than removed them. People try it once, feel that friction, and go back to the group chat method which doesn't pretend to be accurate, it's just a starting point everyone negotiates from.

CRED lets you tag items to specific people. Splitwise lets you adjust individual amounts. GPay gives you one option and calls it done. That's not splitting, that's averaging.

The payment request arrives without any context

When you send a split through GPay, the other people get a payment request notification. That notification looks exactly like every other payment request they've ever received from anyone. There's no 'this is for the Lucknow dhaba dinner on Saturday' attached. Just an amount and your name.

Most people, when they see an unexpected payment request from someone they know, have a moment of uncertainty. What's this for? They might remember. They might not. If they're not sure, they delay until they can ask. If you don't follow up, it just sits there pending.

WhatsApp payments work better in group situations not because the feature is more sophisticated — it genuinely isn't but because the payment request arrives inside the conversation where the dinner was also discussed. The context is right there. The request makes sense without any explanation. GPay's request arrives floating, disconnected from anything, in a tray full of other notifications.

There's no way to see who's paid and who hasn't

After you send the split, you have no clear view of the settlement status. Who's paid, who's still pending, how long each person has been sitting on it. You can piece it together from the transaction history but there's no dashboard that tells you at a glance Priya settled, Rahul is three days overdue.

This matters because the follow-up is the worst part. Nobody wants to send a 'hey you still owe me ₹300' message to a friend. It's awkward. So what happens instead is the person who paid either writes it off mentally or brings it up in person the next time they meet, which is its own kind of awkward.

The workaround — sending a reminder message yourself is something an app should be able to handle. Not aggressively, but a gentle 'just a reminder about Sunday's dinner' that comes from the app rather than from you removes a specific social friction that stops people from using the feature again.

What people do instead — and why it works

When I ask people how they split bills with friends, almost everyone describes the same pattern. One person pays. Puts the total and each person's share in the group chat. People transfer over the next hour or two. Done.

That method is slower, more manual, and requires more back-and-forth than GPay's feature. And yet it wins every time. The reason is worth understanding because it's the key to what a good fix looks like.

The group chat method works because the context and the coordination happen in the same place. The conversation about the dinner and the conversation about who owes what are in the same thread. When Rahul sees '₹350 each guys' in the group chat, he knows immediately what it's for. He can ask a question in the same thread if something's off. Everyone can see the thread so there's no confusion about whether they're included. The social process of settling up which is more complicated than the financial process happens naturally in a space the group already uses.

GPay's split feature extracts the financial part of that process and handles it in isolation. But the financial part isn't what's hard. The hard part is coordination, context, and the social awkwardness of money between friends. The feature solves the easy part and leaves the hard part untouched.

> *People don't keep using the group chat method because they don't know about GPay's feature. They keep using it because it handles the actual problem better — even though it's objectively more work.*

Three things I'd change

I want to be upfront that I'm not proposing a full redesign that's a much bigger document and it would need engineering estimates, actual user research with more than my social circle, and alignment with GPay's broader product strategy. What I'm proposing are three specific changes that address the four problems I identified, in rough order of how much I think they'd move the needle.

1. Let the group form around the split, not before it

Remove the requirement for a pre-existing GPay group. When someone starts a split, let them select contacts in the moment right there, same way you'd share something on WhatsApp. The split session is the group. It doesn't need to persist beyond the settlement.

This is probably the most significant engineering change of the three because it means creating ephemeral split sessions that don't rely on the persistent group infrastructure. But it removes the biggest behavioural barrier. My friend who opened the app and stopped when he saw 'create a group' he would have continued if he could just pick contacts directly.

This isn't a novel idea. Splitwise has done this for years. CRED does it. The pattern exists. What would make GPay's version better than both is that your contacts are already there you don't need to add people manually or hope they're on the app. That's a structural advantage GPay has that Splitwise will never have. It just needs to use it.

2. Make the split reflect what actually happened, not just the math

After entering the total, give two paths. Fast split equal division, done in two taps, for situations where equal genuinely applies. Custom split where you can adjust individual amounts before sending. The custom split doesn't need to be item-level on day one. Just let people modify each person's amount from the equal-split baseline.

That one change adjustable amounts eliminates the friction of the feature producing a number that doesn't match reality. It's not complicated to build. It's a form with editable fields. But it's the difference between a feature that works for real dinners and a feature that works for a hypothetical dinner where everyone ordered exactly the same thing.

The item-level split 'who had what' is a v2 problem. Start with adjustable amounts. Most of the use cases that currently fail would be solved.

3. Give context to the request and automate the follow-up

Two small changes here that together make a big difference. One: when a split request is sent, include a note field pre-populated with something like 'Dinner, [date]' so the recipient understands what they're paying for without having to ask. The sender can edit it. But having a default reduces the friction of filling it in, which means more requests go out with context attached.

Two: if someone hasn't paid 48 hours after a split request was sent, the app sends them a reminder. Not an aggressive one. Something like 'Quick reminder about the dinner split from Aryan.' One tap to pay from the notification. The reminder comes from the app, not from the person who paid — which is the whole point. The social awkwardness of chasing a friend for money disappears when the app is doing the chasing.

The tone of that reminder matters a lot and it would need to be tested. But the mechanism is straightforward and it handles the one part of the group chat method that the app currently can't replace the natural follow-up that happens in conversation.

A quick comparison with what's out there

What matters	GPay	Splitwise	CRED	WhatsApp Pay
Ad-hoc splits (no pre-setup)	No	Yes	Yes	N/A
Custom per-person amounts	No	Yes	Yes	No
Context attached to request	No	Yes	Partial	Yes — thread
Settlement status view	No	Yes	No	No
Auto follow-up reminder	No	Yes	No	No
Everyone already has the app	Yes	No	No	Yes

The last row is the one that matters most. GPay's structural advantage everyone's already on it is enormous. Splitwise solves the feature problem but can never solve the distribution problem. Every time someone tries to use Splitwise at a group dinner, at least one person says 'I'm not on Splitwise' and the whole thing falls apart.

GPay doesn't have that problem. If it closes even half the feature gap with Splitwise, it has a product that should win on every dimension. Right now it's leaving that advantage on the table.

How I'd know if any of this worked

The one number I'd actually watch

Split completion rate of everyone who starts a split, what percentage see all payments come through within 7 days. This is the end-to-end metric. High start rate plus low completion rate means the feature breaks somewhere in the middle. That middle is exactly where the four problems I identified live.

My guess is that this number is currently low not because of technical failures but because of the behavioural ones. If the three changes above work, completion rate should move meaningfully probably more than any discoverability improvement would.

One signal that tells you if the social model changed

Once the pre-existing group requirement is gone, track what percentage of new splits are started with contacts who aren't already in a GPay group. If that number is high if people are doing ad-hoc splits with whoever's at the table it means the social model change worked. People are now forming groups around expenses rather than needing to have planned ahead.

The guardrail I'd watch

Unintended payment rate payments made in response to a split request that the payer immediately disputes or requests a refund on. If the contextual improvements work, people understand what they're paying for and payment happens cleanly. If disputes go up, either the context isn't landing or there's a UX confusion I've missed somewhere in the new flow.

What I initially got wrong

When I first started thinking about this, my assumption was discoverability. The split feature is buried inside Groups, which is not a section most people open regularly. Move it to the home screen, more people find it, more people use it. Clean and simple.

I think that's partly true but mostly wrong. The people at that dinner who had tried the feature once and found it confusing they found it. The feature being hard to find wasn't their problem. Their problem was that when they found it and used it, it didn't match how splitting actually works in a group of friends.

There's a version of a PM who looks at this data, runs an A/B test moving the button, sees a 15% lift in feature opens, and declares success. The usage numbers would improve slightly. The underlying problem that the feature solves a simplified version of a social coordination problem would remain. Users would find it faster and still not find it worth using.

Discoverability matters when the product works and people can't find it. This product is findable but doesn't work for the actual use case. Those need different fixes.

> *Low feature usage can mean 'users can't find it' or it can mean 'users found it, tried it, and it didn't solve their problem.' Before you move the button, figure out which one you're dealing with.*

Why this problem is interesting

Google Pay is a genuinely good product. I use it multiple times a week. The core payment flow is so smooth that it's become completely invisible which is what good payment infrastructure should feel like.

What makes the split problem interesting isn't that GPay got it wrong. It's why. The team clearly thought about this the feature exists, it works technically, it's been there for years. What went wrong isn't engineering competence. It's that splitting a bill looks like a calculation problem from the outside and is actually a social coordination problem from the inside.

The calculation is easy. Divide the amount by the number of people. Anyone can do that in their head. What's hard is the coordination who was there, who had what, who needs to be reminded, who's going to feel awkward about it. Those are social problems, and a payment feature that only handles the financial layer while ignoring the social layer is going to feel incomplete even when it works perfectly.

The three changes I proposed aren't technically complex. None of them would require months of engineering. What they require is a clear understanding of what the actual problem is which took me two weeks of using the product, talking to friends, reading reviews, and being willing to set aside my first instinct about what the problem was.

That's the part of this case study I want to remember. Not the specific fixes. The process of being wrong about what the problem was, figuring out what it actually was, and then finding that the right fix is different from what you would have built if you'd just gone with your first instinct.